The doctrine advocates that India, being the biggest country in South Asia, should extend unilateral concessions to the smaller neighbours. In other words, the doctrine is formulated on India's accommodating approach towards its smaller neighbours on the basis of the principle of non-reciprocity. It recognises the supreme importance of friendly and cordial relations with India's neighbours.

The doctrine is a five-point roadmap to guide the conduct of India's foreign relations with its immediate neighbours. These five principles are as follows:

1. With the neighbours like Bangladesh, Bhutan, Maldives, Nepal and Sri Lanka, India should not ask for reciprocity, but give to them what it can in good faith.

2. No South Asian country should allow its territory to be used against the interest of another country of the region.

3. No country should interfere in the internal affairs of another country.

4. All South Asian countries should respect each other's territorial integrity and sovereignty.

5. All South Asian countries should settle all their disputes through peaceful bilateral negotiations.

Gujral himself explained: "The logic behind the Gujral Doctrine was that since we had to face two hostile neighbours in the north and the west, we had to be at 'total peace' with all other immediate neighbours in order to contain Pakistan's and China's influence in the region."

NUCLEAR DOCTRINE OF INDIA

India's nuclear doctrine can be summarised as follows:[4]

1. Building and maintaining a credible minimum deterrent.

2. A posture of "No First Use" – nuclear weapons will only be used in retaliation against a nuclear attack on Indian territory or on Indian forces anywhere.

3. Nuclear retaliation to a first strike will be massive and designed to inflict unacceptable damage.

4. Nuclear retaliatory attacks can only be authorised by the civilian political leadership through the Nuclear Command Authority.

5. Non-use of nuclear weapons against non-nuclear weapon states.

6. However, in the event of a major attack against India, or Indian forces anywhere, by biological or chemical weapons, India will retain the option of retaliating with nuclear weapons.

7. A continuance of strict controls on export of nuclear and missile related materials and technologies, participation in the Fissile Material Cutoff Treaty negotiations, and continued observance of the moratorium on nuclear tests.

8. Continued commitment to the goal of a nuclear-weapon-free world, through global, verifiable and non-discriminatory nuclear disarmament.